A Short Reference on Modern Indian History

Overview

This short reference covers selected topics from the economic, political and social history of modern India. It is written as a test document for a retrieval system, so each page focuses on one topic and every section begins with a clear heading.

The document has five pages. Page 1 is this overview. Page 2 covers the economic history of the colonial period, with a focus on changes in farming. Page 3 covers independence and the first head of government. Page 4 covers the life of a well-known figure from the ravines of northern India. Page 5 covers a prominent politician from Uttar Pradesh.

India is a large and diverse country, and its modern history includes colonial rule, a long movement for independence, the adoption of a democratic constitution in 1950, and several decades of social and political change. The sections that follow are brief summaries and are not meant to be complete accounts.

Readers who want more detail should consult standard textbooks and primary sources. Dates and figures in this document are rounded where exact values are disputed.

Commercialization of Agriculture, 1860-1920

The commercialization of agriculture in British India began around 1860 and continued until about 1920. During this period, many farmers shifted from growing food grains for local use to growing cash crops for sale in distant markets, including markets overseas. The most important cash crops were cotton, jute, indigo, sugarcane, tea, opium and oilseeds.

Several forces drove this change. The growth of the railway network lowered transport costs and connected inland villages to ports. The American Civil War of the early 1860s reduced cotton supplies to British mills, which raised both the demand for Indian cotton and its price. The opening of the Suez Canal in 1869 shortened the sea route to Europe and made exports cheaper to ship.

Land revenue under colonial rule had to be paid in cash, so peasants needed money to meet the demand. Many sold their crops to traders at harvest time, when prices were low, and borrowed from moneylenders when they needed cash. Debt became a lasting problem for small farmers in several regions.

The effects were uneven. Some regions, traders and large landholders gained from rising exports. Many small cultivators, however, became dependent on markets they could not control, and the late nineteenth century saw several severe famines. Historians still debate how far commercialization helped or harmed the Indian peasant.

Independence and Jawaharlal Nehru

India became independent on 15 August 1947. Jawaharlal Nehru became the first prime minister of independent India and held the office until his death on 27 May 1964, a period of almost seventeen years.

Jawaharlal Nehru was born on 14 November 1889 in Allahabad. He studied at Cambridge and trained as a barrister in London before returning to India. He became a leading figure of the Indian National Congress and a close associate of Mahatma Gandhi in the struggle against British rule. He spent many years in prison for his part in the freedom movement, and he wrote several books, including The Discovery of India.

On the eve of independence, Nehru delivered a famous speech known as Tryst with Destiny to the Constituent Assembly. As prime minister he pursued planned economic development through Five-Year Plans, the first of which began in 1951. In foreign affairs he followed a policy of non-alignment during the Cold War.

His birthday, 14 November, is celebrated in India as Children's Day.

Phoolan Devi, the Bandit Queen

Phoolan Devi is known as the Bandit Queen of India. She was born in 1963 in a village in Uttar Pradesh into a poor family from the Mallah community. Married very young, she later left her husband and became the leader of a gang of dacoits operating in the Chambal ravines.

In 1981 she was linked to the killing of about twenty men in the village of Behmai, an event that made her one of the most wanted people in the country. In 1983 she surrendered to the authorities in Madhya Pradesh in a public ceremony attended by a large crowd.

During her eleven-year imprisonment Phoolan Devi was befriended by a writer, Mala Sen, who published her story in 1991 as India's Bandit Queen: The True Story of Phoolan Devi. A film called Bandit Queen, directed by Shekhar Kapur, followed in 1994.

Phoolan Devi was released in 1994 and entered politics. She was elected to the Lok Sabha in 1996 from Mirzapur and won the seat again in 1999. She was assassinated outside her home in New Delhi on 25 July 2001.

Mayawati and Uttar Pradesh Politics

Mayawati is an Indian politician and the leader of the Bahujan Samaj Party. She was born on 15 January 1956 in Delhi and worked as a teacher before entering politics under the guidance of the party founder, Kanshi Ram.

She first became Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh in June 1995. Her first term as chief minister lasted less than five months. She was the first Dalit woman to serve as chief minister of an Indian state.

She returned to the office in 1997 for a short term of about six months, and again from 2002 to 2003. After her party won a majority in the 2007 state election, she served a full five-year term, which ended in 2012.

Besides her work in the state, Mayawati has served as a member of both houses of the national parliament, the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha. Her career is often cited as an example of the growing political role of Dalit communities in Uttar Pradesh.